

Battle ready: Osaka displayed the form that brought her two Australian Open and two U.S. Open titles from 2018 to 2021. REUTERS

matches and often ended with winners or forced errors. Anisimova smacked forehand return winners on break points to level at 2-all and again at 5-all. But Osaka built an insurmountable 6-1 lead and seized the tie-break 7-4. At 4-all in the second set, *ESPN* analyst Chris Evert said, "Who is going to be more fearless and take control?"

Both competitors blasted shots fearlessly, yet they lacked self-confidence in another telling respect. During the taut second set, Tomasz Wiktorowski used in-match coaching to advise Osaka to serve wide and go more to her opponent's backhand. On the other end, coach Rick Vleeshouwers reminded Anisimova to calm down.

In the deciding set, Anisimova got the only break she needed to pull ahead 3-1. Winners were coming from everywhere, more so from the American. She blasted winners with a swinging volley, an ace, and a forehand to hold for 4-1. Both players fought desperately when Anisimova served for the title at 5-3. Osaka staved off three championship points and Anisimova two break points.

Fittingly, the unrelenting Anisimova closed out the 6-7(4), 7-6(3), 6-3 battle with a backhand winner, her 50th overall, and potent forehands that forced Osaka to err, ending the enthralling duel at 12:55 a.m. On reaching her first U.S. Open final, Anisimova said, "It means the world. It's just absolutely a dream come true."

Sabalenka felt the same way. She enlivened the usually perfunctory and short pre-match interview when she told *ESPN's* Mary Joe Fernandez, "It's a dream. I'm living a dream life."

Although the Belarusian Basher had not suffered a straight-sets loss in 104 matches — a little-known stat second only to Martina Navratilova's record of 143 and a testament to her elite-level consistency — the streak seemed in jeopardy in her semifinal against the redoubtable Jessica



Pegula (**right**). Although the world No. 4 hadn't lost a set, she hadn't played a seeded opponent either.

The defending finalist — she lost 7-5, 7-5 to Sabalenka a year ago — grabbed 16 of the last 20 points to take the opening set against Sabalenka in the semis. **But the momentum abruptly switched as Sabalenka's power and versatility more than offset Jessica's solid, precise shots and wonderful anticipation.** The only drama came at 3-2 in the deciding set when Sabalenka fought off two break points and in the final game, lasting 10 points, when she served for the match at 5-4. After Sabalenka belted a forehand winner to wrap up the 4-6, 6-3, 6-4 victory, she shrieked in ecstasy.

The oddsmakers made Sabalenka a -200 favourite with Anisimova at +170, but Anisimova, the youngest woman at 24 to reach the Wimbledon and U.S. Open finals in the same year since Serena and Venus Williams in 2002, had more than a puncher's chance.

Had Anisimova, who just two years ago was taking online classes during her mental health break from the tour, expended so much emotional energy that she had little left for the title round? When she lost her serve twice to trail 5-3, Mary Joe Fernandez said, "I think she's feeling the occasion more than Sabalenka. I saw her in the gym working out [before the match]."

The American received a standing ovation from the partisan crowd when she broke serve to make it 5-all just after Sabalenka was two points from victory. Sabalenka dumped a routine overhead into the net at 30-all. Some wondered if her nerves would hold up, but the new, calmer Sabalenka brushed it off with a wry smile.

Not surprisingly, the Belarusian took the tie-break 7-3. After all, she had won an astounding 19 tie-breaks in a row, an Open Era record.

The 6-3, 7-6 (3) triumph reaffirmed her reign as the Queen of Hard Courts.

